

atmosphere and buried him." Former Indian coach John Wright said from New Zealand, "I don't believe Harbhajan was talking in a vacuum out there, knowing how the Australians play the game in the middle." It is believed that the moment the partnership began to build between Harbhajan and Sachin Tendulkar, the Australians began mouthing off against the spinner in the belief that they would get him to lose his cool and his wicket.

The conduct of the Australians led respected cricket writer Peter Roebuck to call the world champions "a pack of wild dogs" and ask for Ponting to be sacked. Opinion polls in leading Australian newspapers echoed that view. The Australians, however, claimed that ICC had been bullied by BCCI and put up visuals of "racist" T-shirts being sold in India on their website, in a breathtaking turnaround of Indian anger and entrepreneurship.

What the Sydney Test has thrown up is the issue of racism in the sport and the competence and compliance of the men who supervise the game on the field, the two umpires and the match referee. In fact, the collective anger in the Indian camp and the unanimous decision to pull out of the series if Harbhajan's ban was enforced was not

COOL HEAD:
Kumble has handled the whole crisis with grace and dignity



AFP PHOTO/ PRAKASH SINGH

just over the objectionable behaviour of the Australian team, the decision by Procter or the pathetic umpiring decisions, but the manner in which some players were treated.

Procter called the Australians and the Indians for a marathon hearing on Harbhajan. Matthew Hayden and Michael Clarke testified that Harbhajan had passed a racial remark by calling Symonds "monkey".

Lee was not called in, probably to prevent him from diluting his own team's case.

Ponting backed his players stating that Harbhajan was a repeat offender having called Symonds a "monkey" in the last ODI between the two countries. It is a charge denied by the Indians. To rub salt into their wounds, after five days of playing tough, emotionally and physically draining cricket, they were called for a hearing at 8 o'clock on the fifth day which went on till 3 a.m. During that period, the organisers did not have the courtesy to offer the Indian players and officials, who testified, tea or snacks. What further fuelled the Indian anger was the man-



AP PHOTO/RICK RYCROFT

Bucknor's Bloomers

His mistakes have often changed the course of a match

- In the 1999-00 Kolkata Test against Pakistan, Sachin Tendulkar failed to complete a run as he was obstructed by Shoaib Akhtar. Akhtar appealed for run out and Bucknor, instead of taking notice of the obstruction, referred to the third umpire who ruled Tendulkar out.
- In the 1992-93 Wanderers Test, Jonty Rhodes was run out when he was on 11 but Bucknor did not give him out. When Indian players requested him to take the help of third umpire Bucknor refused. South Africa were 73 for 5 but Rhodes's 91 helped them draw the Test.
- In the 2003-04 Brisbane Test against

Australia, Bucknor ruled Tendulkar LBW out when the ball hit on a knee roll and the line was just outside the off-stump.

- In the 2004-05 Kolkata Test, Bucknor gave Tendulkar out caught behind when his bat clearly missed the ball from Abdul Razzaq. Tendulkar had earlier complained to Bucknor about poor light.
- In the 2007 Lord's Test, he ruled Sreesanth not out off the bowling of Monty Panesar on the last day of the match. Replays show that Sreesanth was plumb in front of the wicket. The decision helped India draw this Test.

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